the finisher, held back for the big push. He keeps wicket to the white ball but concentrates on his batting in Test matches. His character is trusted by the men he serves as vice-captain, Eoin Morgan and Joe Root.

There are parallels with young players emerging in English football. They are unafraid of self-expression and take great pride in the extravagant skills they developed playing cage football as kids. They are quick-witted, and ready to try new tricks on the biggest stage. They will not sacrifice their enthusiasm because they are not scared of failure.

Buttler is a kindred spirit in that respect. His response when a photographer noticed that he had written ‘Fuck it’ on his bat handle was revealing. ‘It puts cricket in perspective,’ he explained. ‘When you nick off, does it really matter?’ In the great scheme of things, no. To a captain or coach craving stability and security, perhaps yes.

Jos had played thirty-one Tests over five years until the summer of 2019, averaging nearly 36 and scoring a single century, 106 against India in 2018. It hasn’t been an easy ride, with Geoffrey Boycott characteristically suggesting ‘a seven-year-old schoolboy would have played better’ in the 2015 Ashes, but his determination to excel is admirable.

He speaks about having ‘fun’ learning new strokes. His favourite is the ramp shot, over the wicketkeeper. Confidence is a transferable item; he understands he can’t play those shots with such freedom in Test cricket and wouldn’t do so indiscriminately, but he reserves the right to employ an element of surprise. Bowlers think they know what they are dealing with, and plan accordingly, but can be knocked out of their stride.

They also appreciate the allure of the five-day game, even when they make their name, and their fortune, in four-over bursts in franchise cricket. Jofra Archer, Buttler’s teammate with Rajasthan Royals, seized the imagination when he qualified for England and was selected for the 2019 World Cup. His ability to bowl with speed and accuracy, to deliver smoothly at 95 mph, is applicable across the game.

Look into his background, and you will find the examples of commitment above and beyond the call of duty that are common among successful athletes. He remodelled his action following back problems after being discovered playing club cricket by Sussex, and even rolled his own mud wicket so he could practise at home in Barbados.

I have no problem with Archer shifting allegiance to England. We live in an age where nationalities are becoming blurred across all sports. At the last